Nils Handler

Environmental Economist

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Education

Berlin School of Economics, Economics — Berlin, Germany — Oct 2019 – Dec 2026
- Structured economics PhD, intake below 4%, fully funded
- Focus on Environmental Economics, Technological Change and Energy Transition
- Committee: Marion Dumas (LSE), Ottmar Edenhofer (TU Berlin), Jan Steckel (TUM)
- Research fellow at MIT Sloan School of Management (3 months, academic host Prof. Jacquelyn Pless)
- Research fellow at the Grantham Research Institute on Climate Change, LSE (1 year)
- Research fellow at Imperial College London (1 year, remotely)
- Fellow Innovation Growth Lab (since 2025), seed grant (US$5k, 2026)

Barcelona Graduate School of Economics, International Trade, Finance and Development — Barcelona, Spain — Sept 2017 – July 2018

London School of Economics and Political Science (LSE), Political Economy of Late Development — London, UK — Sept 2011 – Sept 2012
- Distinction, top 5%

University of Tübingen, International Economics and American Studies — Tübingen, Germany — Oct 2007 – July 2011
- Exchange year at Universidade de São Paulo, Brazil (2009 to 2010)

Experience

Office of the President, University of Zurich, Project Leader Climate Neutrality — Zurich, Switzerland — Aug 2024 – present — 2 years 3 months
- Built and lead an evidence-based decarbonization agenda, budget CHF 1.2M, leading five data scientists
- Developed the concept for the world's first university buyers club for durable carbon dioxide removal (CDR)
- Built a strategic partnership with Terralytiq for AI-supported product carbon footprinting and assessed the emissions impact of AI applications at the institution

External Consultant (remote), BMW Foundation and Breakthrough Energy — Apr 2024 – July 2024 — 4 months
- BMW Foundation: developed thematic strategy on energy resilience, delivered 10+ concept papers and storylines to the new leadership team, supported global trade dialogue with Columbia University
- Breakthrough Energy: led economic modelling for the report Investing in Net Zero: Assessing Germany's venture capital potential in climate tech until 2030

Federal Institute for Geosciences and Natural Resources (BGR), Economist and Project Manager, International Cooperation Program — Hannover, Germany — Sept 2018 – June 2021 — 2 years 10 months
- Modelled US$6.5B in climate-critical mineral procurement spend and built Tableau-recognised analytics infrastructure
- LION tool presented to the Ministry of Mines Permanent Secretary and the German Ambassador, triggering a cabinet briefing
- Coordinated stakeholders across Africa and Europe, led World Bank and OECD Natural Resource Policy Dialogue

World Bank, Economist working on Energy, Trade and Competitiveness, various Global Practices — Washington D.C., USA, Dec 2014 – June 2023, 8 years 7 months

- Led Mining Investment and Governance Review (MInGov): managing engagements and quality control
- Organised global conference (budget above US$200K), mapped green competitiveness policies across 25+ countries
- Drafted DRC Economic Memorandum covering entrepreneurial ecosystem, skills mapping and EV value-chain analysis

Inter-American Development Bank (IADB), Junior Economist and Carlo Schmid Fellow — Washington D.C., USA, Sept 2012 – Nov 2014, 2 years 3 months

- Quantitative and qualitative research on fiscal decentralisation and extractive industry revenue, 10+ publications
- Participated in Board Meetings, briefed Governors via constituency report for the IDB Annual Meeting

Publications

Entrepreneurial ecosystems, economic complexity, and venture-oriented entrepreneurship in German regions — 2026
Nils Handler, M. Brachert
10.1007/s11187-026-01278-5 (Small Business Economics)

Informing net-zero policies in the European Union with evidence-based approaches — 2025
Nils Handler, A. Löschel, M. Braun, V. Grimm
www.nature.com/articles/s44359-025-00063-z (Nature Reviews Clean Technology)

Stranded nations? Transition risks and opportunities towards a clean economy — 2023
P. Andres, P. Mealy, *Nils Handler*, S. Fankhauser
www.smithschool.ox.ac.uk/news/stranded-nations-research-reveals-countries-could-be-left-behind-net-zero-transition (Environmental Research Letters)

Randomised controlled trials: Can they inform the development of green innovation policies in the UK? — 2022
S. Esin, *Nils Handler*, L. Morey, A. Munjal
www.lse.ac.uk/granthaminstitute/publication/randomised-controlled-trials-can-they-inform-the-development-of-green-innovation-policies-in-the-uk (Policy insight, Grantham Research Institute on Climate Change and the Environment, LSE)

Work in Progress

Relatedness and Regional Development in Germany: Evidence on Skills, Technologies, Industries, and Complexity
Handler, N., Brachert, M., Kubis, A. (R&R Research Policy)

Reducing emissions in the laboratory: Evidence from a randomized evaluation of a sustainable practice and accreditation scheme
Handler, N., Rutnam, D., Harrington Ruiz, N.

Unlocking Innovation: Experimental Evidence on Barriers to Public R&D Funding Uptake
Handler, N.

Growing Clean? Directing Technological Change in Germany
Handler, N., Brachert, M.

Modeling the impact of IT- and AI-related emissions in a university setting
Poletto, M., Handler, N.

Seminar Presentations

Conference on Field Experiments in Strategy (CFXS)
07/2026

Regis Summer School with Prof. Gaétan de Rassenfosse
06/2026

AFID User Workshop, ZEW Mannheim
04/2026

Institut d'Economia de Barcelona, Universitat de Barcelona
2026

DRUID Innovation PhD Workshop, Aarhus (2026) and DRUID conference, Lisbon (2024)
2024, 2026

Innovation Growth Lab (virtual, twice) and Amsterdam Workshop
2020, 2025

ifo Workshop, Fürth
2025

Harvard Growth Lab
2023, 2024

European Union Joint Research Centre, Sevilla
2024

Advances in Field Experiments, Chicago
2023, 2026

WICK10, Turin
2023

Teaching and Supervision

Energy Data Lab: leveraging RCTs for Campus Decarbonization
Secured CHF 30k UZH funding (2025, 2026)

HEC Paris, Lecturer, MBA Climate and Business Certificate
Climate Policy and Green Growth (2023)

ETH Zurich, HEC and Hertie School Berlin
Executive trainings on energy policy (2023, 2024, 2025)

MSc Dissertation Supervision
Nigel Yao (Oxford, distinction), Lewis Morrey (LSE), Apurva Munjal (LSE)

Reviewing Activity

Research Policy
Reviewer

Awards

Hans Weisser Fellowship
2023. US research stay and academic networking on the East and West Coast on how to leverage field experiments for more evidence-based climate policies

Young Global Changer, Global Solutions Initiative
2022

Energy Transition PhD Fellowship, Academic Merit Foundation of German Businesses
2020 to 2024

Scholarship, Academic Merit Foundation of German Protestant Churches
2009 to 2012

Trainings

Electricity Markets (Lion Hirth)
2024

Using Text as Data: Methods and Applications, Barcelona School of Economics
2022

Economic Foundations for Energy and Climate Policy, DIW Berlin
2019

Skills

Data Analysis

Languages

German
Native

English
C2

Spanish
C2

Portuguese
C2

French
B1